

The Modes of the Melodic Minor Scale

The **melodic minor scale** is one of the most powerful tools in modern guitar playing. Unlike the natural minor, it raises the 7th degree, giving it a brighter, more forward-moving sound while retaining a minor tonality. From this parent scale, we can derive **seven distinct modes**, each with its own unique colour, mood, and harmonic function.

Think of these modes as the “flavours” that melodic minor brings to the fretboard. Many legendary players—like **John McLaughlin, Allan Holdsworth, Frank Gambale, Joe Satriani, and John Coltrane**—have used them extensively to add sophistication and tension to their music.

Mode 1: Melodic Minor (a.k.a. Jazz Minor)

Formula: 1 – 2 – $\flat 3$ – 4 – 5 – 6 – 7

This is the parent scale itself. It sounds like a natural minor with a raised 7th, which gives it a more “leading” quality.

- **Chord Tones:** Minor-major 7 (mMaj7)
 - **Uses:** Over minor chords with a major 7th (e.g., AmMaj7). Excellent for fusion, jazz, and film scoring.
 - **Sound:** Dark yet elegant, mysterious with forward motion.
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Mode 2: Dorian $\flat 2$ (a.k.a. Phrygian $\flat 6$)

Formula: 1 – $\flat 2$ – $\flat 3$ – 4 – 5 – 6 – $\flat 7$

Think of it as **Phrygian** but with a natural 6.

- **Chord Tones:** m7 chord with added tension (sus quality).
 - **Uses:** Great for exotic, Spanish, or Middle Eastern moods. Works over m7 $\flat 9$ chords.
 - **Sound:** Dark and mysterious, but less heavy than pure Phrygian thanks to the natural 6.
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Mode 3: Lydian Augmented

Formula: 1 – 2 – 3 – $\sharp 4$ – $\sharp 5$ – 6 – 7

This mode is **Lydian with a raised 5th**, which gives it a dreamy but powerful edge.

- **Chord Tones:** Maj7 $\sharp 5$ chord.
 - **Uses:** Over maj7 $\sharp 5$ or maj7 chords to add shimmering tension.
 - **Sound:** Expansive, spacey, surreal—think of floating in a cosmic dream.
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Mode 4: Lydian Dominant (a.k.a. Overtone Scale)

Formula: 1 – 2 – 3 – #4 – 5 – 6 – b7

One of the most used melodic minor modes. It's like **Mixolydian with a raised 4th**.

- **Chord Tones:** Dominant 7 with #11 (7#11).
 - **Uses:** Perfect over dominant chords that need more colour (e.g., G7#11). Widely used in jazz and fusion.
 - **Sound:** Bright, funky, modern. Steve Vai and Scott Henderson use this extensively.
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Mode 5: Mixolydian b6 (a.k.a. Hindu Scale)

Formula: 1 – 2 – 3 – 4 – 5 – b6 – b7

This is Mixolydian with a darker edge (b6).

- **Chord Tones:** Dominant 7b13.
 - **Uses:** Over V7 chords when you want more tension without going fully altered. Works well in jazz and fusion progressions.
 - **Sound:** A mix of bright and dark; exotic with a hint of unresolved tension.
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Mode 6: Aeolian b5 (a.k.a. Locrian #2)

Formula: 1 – 2 – b3 – 4 – b5 – b6 – b7

A variant of Locrian that sounds slightly more open due to the natural 2.

- **Chord Tones:** m7b5 (half-diminished).
 - **Uses:** Over half-diminished chords in minor ii–V–I progressions (e.g., Dm7b5 in a ii–V–i in C minor).
 - **Sound:** Tense, unstable, but smoother than pure Locrian.
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Mode 7: Altered Scale (a.k.a. Super Locrian)

Formula: 1 – b2 – b3 – b4 – b5 – b6 – b7

The king of tension. Every possible alteration of the dominant chord is inside this scale.

- **Chord Tones:** Dominant 7 with b9, #9, b5, #5.
- **Uses:** Over V7alt chords resolving to minor or major.
- **Sound:** Highly dissonant, modern, and spicy. Coltrane, Holdsworth, and McLaughlin used this constantly.

Practical Application for Guitarists

- **ii–V–I in minor:**
 - ii (m7 $\flat$ 5) → Mode 6 (Locrian $\sharp$ 2)
 - V7alt → Mode 7 (Altered)
 - i (mMaj7) → Mode 1 (Melodic Minor)
- **Dominant Colouring:** Use **Mode 4 (Lydian Dominant)** or **Mode 5 (Mixolydian $\flat$ 6)** for dominant chords when standard Mixolydian feels too plain.
- **Fusion & Rock Improvisation:** Modes 3, 4, and 7 give you outside, modern soloing flavours.

Closing Thoughts

The **modes of melodic minor** unlock a new level of colour and sophistication on the fretboard. They give you access to sounds ranging from mysterious and exotic to bright and modern to tense and explosive. Master them slowly, apply them in real harmonic contexts, and you'll discover that these modes are the secret language behind some of the most powerful improvisers in history.

Peace, Rob Lobasso 🧐🎸🤘